

THAT MATTER

LALU PRASAD Forced to quit as chief minister of Bihar after being implicated in the fodder scam of 2004, Lalu moves to Delhi as the rail minister in the UPA government, turning the loss-making Indian Railways into a profit-making unit.



SHARAD PAWAR The great Maratha dreams of becoming prime minister one day. He quits in disgust after Sonia Gandhi takes over as the party chief to start his own party in 1999, the NCP, which now supports the Congress-led UPA Government.



MAMATA BANERJEE The fire-brand leader from West Bengal starts her political career with the Congress, but after being expelled, launched the Trinamool Congress in 1997. Currently the rail minister in the UPA, her battleground remains Bengal where she aims to wrest power from the Marxists in the 2011 polls, after 34 years of Left rule.



MAYAWATI After 15 years of hung assemblies in Uttar Pradesh, her BSP emerges as the single largest party in 2007 and she becomes chief minister for the fourth time. However, her ambitions exceed the boundaries of her home state. Forms the Fourth Front during the 2009 General Elections but it bites the dust.



own histories, to decide who they were and how many they were and have helped to re-imagine their past and identities and folk theories of social justice.

At first glance, the post-Independence nationalist elite's efforts of creating an equal and casteless society look like miserable failures. But, as the rise of regional parties shows, the idea of equality (at least social, if not economic) has made important inroads in the popular consciousness, and paradoxically, it has been working towards equality and freedom through democratic means, particularly through voting, which has, and is, promoting the political use of caste and its social reinvention into quasi-ethnic communities. When caste re-enters the political arena as 'samaj' mobilised by caste-based political parties, rather than weakening the demo-

they are entitled to and what they think other communities are not entitled to have. It follows that if 10 years ago local communities were busy trying to get entitlements, now they are focusing on preventing other communities from getting them if necessary. An expression of this emerging state of affairs is indeed strategic caste voting. In areas with high level of caste polarisation, people do not vote for parties in order to gain selective benefits but communities also vote against parties to prevent losing benefits. In a world in which "the enemy of my enemy is my friend", people vote against the least preferred option. It is with this complex reality that the new generation of 'cosmopolitan-provincial' politicians will have to deal. The rustic 'rural' politicians of the last decade have now paved the way for the entry of their children into politics.

SPIN-OFFS

Corridors of Power

Regional Satraps A throwback to princely fiefdoms, each regional leader descends on Delhi, summons leaders to its state bhavans and then

bargains hard over lending support.

Outside Support The regional parties tend to offer support but without being part of the government. By doing so, if any of their demands are not met, they can withdraw support, like J. Jayalalithaa



did with the NDA in 1999 and the Left and TRS with the UPA in 2008.

Horse-trading Negotiating a payoff for support.

It need not necessarily be cash. Can also be in the form of expensive accessories like SUVs.

UPA & NDA Two acronyms of governance, one a "secular coalition" led by the Congress and the other led by the BJP, supported by their regional allies.

cratic process, caste generally strengthens it. Increased levels of political competition have improved the representation of the citizens. Through political participation, the lower strata seems to be able to get state resources previously inaccessible to them. However, the mobilisation strategies of rival regional parties are also contributing to competing ideas of social justice which are creating not only stronger caste identities but legitimising low level conflict and division on the ground.

In Uttar Pradesh, for example, the conflict between the OBC and Dalit communities has been exacerbated over the past 10 years, and the image of a *goonda*, styled as a man who can get things done, has emerged as increasingly attractive for leaders and their followers. In the last decade the competition over state resources and for political posts between the BSP and the SP have shaped what local communities think

This emerging political class still dress in white kurtas when campaigning but are nonetheless educated abroad and campaign with BlackBerries in hand. They are young and fashion-conscious, speak fluent English, but at the same time know how to speak a more rustic vernacular political language and are linked by blood to their constituencies in what has been called a 'dynastic democracy'. The ideas about caste and identity that have been so important in making their fathers and grandfathers successful are now complemented by higher levels of education and an entrepreneurial spirit. This combination could see caste politics and regional political parties develop in a different direction over the next decade.

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